VS Code for the First Time

Windows Edition

The editor everyone uses. Here's how to set it up properly.

`download` · `install` · `extensions` · `theme` · `shortcuts`

Why VS Code?

It's free, fast, and runs everything — from HTML files to full Python projects.

Free forever

Made by Microsoft, open source. No subscriptions, no paywalls.

Extensions

Add support for any language or tool in two clicks from the marketplace.

Fast & lightweight

Opens instantly. Handles single files and huge projects equally well.

Built-in Terminal

Run PowerShell or CMD without leaving the editor. Code and terminal, side by side.

STEP 01

Download & Install

1. Go to **code.visualstudio.com** — click the big blue Download button. It auto-detects Windows and offers a `.exe` installer.
2. Run the installer. When prompted, check **"Add to PATH"** and **"Add Open with Code to context menu"** — both are worth enabling.
3. Also check **"Register Code as an editor for supported file types"** so VS Code opens code files by default.
4. Click through the rest and hit **Install**. Launch VS Code when the installer finishes.

After install: Open a new Command Prompt or PowerShell and run `code .` in any folder to open it in VS Code instantly. If the command isn't found, restart your PC — PATH changes need a fresh session.

STEP 02

Install 5 Essential Extensions

Open the Extensions panel with `Ctrl Shift X`, then search by name.

Prettier
`esbenp.prettier-vscode`
Auto-formats your code on save. Never argue about indentation again.

ESLint
`dbaeumer.vscode-eslint`
Underlines JS/TS mistakes in real time before you even run the code.

indent-rainbow
`oderwat.indent-rainbow`
Colors each indentation level. Instantly spot misaligned blocks.

Material Icon Theme
`pkief.material-icon-theme`
Adds file-type icons to the sidebar. Makes navigating projects much faster.

GitHub Copilot
`github.copilot`
AI autocomplete for code. Free for students, paid otherwise — worth it.

STEP 03

Change Your Theme

The default theme is fine. These are better.

HOW TO CHANGE IT

Press `Ctrl K` then `Ctrl T` to open the theme picker. Arrow keys preview in real time.

OR VIA COMMAND PALETTE

Press `Ctrl Shift P`, type `color theme`, hit Enter.

One Dark Pro Most popular dark theme
`zhuangtongfa.material-theme`

GitHub Dark Clean, familiar from GitHub
`github.github-vscode-theme`

Catppuccin Soft pastel dark theme
`catppuccin.catppuccin-vsc`

Solarized Light Best light theme, built-in
`no install needed`

STEP 04

Enable Autosave

VS Code does **not** autosave by default. Fix this immediately.

OPTION A — MENU

Go to **File → Auto Save**. One click. Done. A checkmark appears when it's on.

OPTION B — SETTINGS

Press `Ctrl ,` to open Settings. Search `autosave`. Set to **afterDelay** (1000ms default).

The dot on the tab means **unsaved changes**. Once autosave is on, you'll never see it again.

Recommended setting: `afterDelay` at 1000ms — saves one second after you stop typing. Fast enough to feel instant, without saving every single keystroke.

Key Shortcuts Cheatsheet

Shortcut	What it does	When to use it
`Ctrl P`	Quick Open — find any file	Jump between files instantly
`Ctrl Shift P`	Command Palette	Run any VS Code command by name
`Ctrl ` `	Toggle integrated Terminal	Run commands without leaving VS Code
`Ctrl B`	Toggle sidebar	More screen space when coding
`Ctrl \`	Split editor	View two files side by side
`Ctrl Shift F`	Search across all files	Find anything in the whole project
`Ctrl D`	Select next occurrence	Multi-cursor rename in one go
`Ctrl Z / Ctrl Y`	Undo / Redo	Your safety net — always works
`Ctrl /`	Toggle line comment	Comment out code in any language
`Ctrl Shift X`	Open Extensions panel	Install, manage, disable extensions

VS Code is ready.

Start building.

You've got the editor, the extensions, and the shortcuts.

Check out my other tutorials →

More things you can build with AI